

SPACESHIPONE

Reusable manned spacecraft

SpaceShipOne, piloted by Mike Melville, reached space on 21 June 2004, becoming the first privately built spacecraft to do so. It was launched from the carrier plane White Knight at an altitude of 14 km (9 miles) before firing its own rockets to propel it beyond Earth's atmosphere. Virgin Galactic is building a larger version, SpaceShipTwo, which will carry six paying "space tourists".

SpaceShipOne was only designed to carry a pilot and two customers.

Vertical booms and horizontal stabilizers on the wings helped the spacecraft remain stable when re-entering the atmosphere

The fuselage and wings are made of lightweight carbon-based materials

DATA FILE



SIZE: 8.5 m (28 ft) long



FIRST MANNED FLIGHT TO SPACE:
21 June 2004



NUMBER OF MISSIONS: 3 (last flight
4 October 2004)



MANUFACTURER: Scaled Composites
(private company)